What the Moodle system administrator does

Goals for this topic

We want to

Understand what Moodle system administrator does

Get a better idea of the different roles in Moodle and how these roles are assigned

Set up data to help us explore the system administrator's job, understand Moodle better and have something to work with in the following sections of the course

Where to get help with Moodle

There is plenty of ‘how to’ material available on the Web

- First port of call (after the material we supply to you) is always moodle.org
  - Click on Documentation
  - There is lots of material directed at admins and at teachers
- Search with specific questions on the Web

Be clear what you are looking for/getting
Help for the admin on the technical steps or for a teacher on setting up a course in pedagogically valuable ways

Who does what

Moodle has a hierarchy of roles
Teacher can do all a non-editing teacher can do
Non-editing teacher can do all a student can do

- Site administrator - can "do everything" on the site
- Manager - a lesser administrator role
- Course creator - can create courses
- Teacher - can manage and add content to courses
- Non-editing teacher can grade in courses but not edit them
- Student - can access and participate in courses
- Guest - can view courses but not participate
- Authenticated user - the role all logged in users have
- Authenticated user on the front page role - a logged in user role for the front page only

From https://docs.moodle.org/39/en/Standard_roles

We will focus on admin, teacher, non-editing teacher and student

Moodle has an extensive system of allowing for changes of roles depending on contexts
This is done via linking roles with capabilities

Who does what

The admin user

Has access to everything available via the Moodle web user interface

Think about it – why do I emphasize ‘web user interface’?

Can setup courses, users, enrolments

- Why ‘can’?
- We will use the admin account to setup such data manually
- In any reasonably-sized organization this will be automated

Makes site-wide settings

- E.g., give the site a name, change the appearance, the ‘look’ of the Moodle site
- Set the mail server the Moodle site uses

Who does what

The other users

If we are exact, we cannot say that a user is (in Moodle) a teacher or student

A user with the account name ‘bbirch’ can be

- A teacher in the course ‘Accounting 101’
- A non-editing teacher in the course ‘Finance Intro’
- A student in the course ‘How to grow tomatoes’

A user takes on a role in a specific context

The default settings (we have looked at the overview) determine what the user can do in this role

Often we will use language that is not 100% precise

I might say ‘log in as teacher’

I should say ‘log in with a user account who has the role of teacher in your course’

Who does what

We will use our admin account

To setup courses and user accounts

To make enrolments

This means to define which user has access to which course in which role

As mentioned, in a real installation these data come from somewhere

E.g., from the enrolment system, the staff database, the system that knows which courses our education institution (or company) offers

For the purpose of doing 158.120 it is your task to think of a sensible example

Think whom your Moodle site is for

Create some sensible courses

Add real sounding users

Do not use something like user1, user2, ...

Do not enter anything potentially offensive

Do not enter any confidential data

Who does what

My example data

Accounting 101

Teacher
- Betty Birch

Non-editing teacher
- Otto Oak

Students
- Berta Beagle
- Paula Pigeon
- Sally Spaniel
- Seth Spider
- Warren Wolf

Finance 123

Teacher
- Betty Birch

Non-editing teacher
- Warren Wolf

Students
- Berta Beagle
- Paula Pigeon
- Sally Spaniel
- Seth Spider

Please write your data on a piece of paper (or in a word processing document) so you can refer back to them when working with Moodle

Who does what

The teacher (meaning a user with the role teacher in a course)

Can set some parameters for the course

- Which blocks show and where
- Who many topic blocks are there for the course

Can add resources

- Files, pages, links, labels

Can add activities

- Forums, quizzes, assignments, surveys, choices

Can add users in roles ‘below’ teacher

- Add a postgrad student as non-editing teacher

Can monitor what everyone is doing

- When did a student last login
- Who has looked at specific resources

As we are looking at Moodle as an IT system we are only interested in what a teacher can do not how they do it to support learning well

Using Moodle well requires lots of thinking on pedagogy

Who does what

The non-editing teacher

Is more limited, e.g.

- Can grade an assignment but cannot setup an assignment
- Can see everything that is on the course (inclusive parts hidden from students) but can generally not change any settings

Once you have setup your data you should explore

In a real context it can be challenging to determine who should have access to a course in which role

As usual, you will find that the technical steps are easy, the challenges come from finding a consensus that is as fair and sensible as possible

Who does what

The student

Is pretty much limited, e.g.

- Cannot make changes to the course site
- Needs to work within the parameters set by the teacher
- For some activities can only see their own data

What would be examples?

You have the student experience from Stream

Now you can see Moodle also from the teacher perspective

Who does what

Can the admin user do the teacher tasks?

Technically, yes

Should they? No!

Administrator and teacher are conceptually very different roles

- Administrator: Primary concerns are to keep Moodle functional, setup the right users/structures, monitor Moodle's performance, ...
- Teacher: Primary concern is to support the learning of the students in their course

Moodle keeps logs of who does what

- E.g., who updated an activity when

You have access to both the admin and the teacher accounts for your site

- Be aware that you as one person take on different roles (admin, teacher, student)
- Choose the right account to do a task
- E.g., if you want to add an assignment to a course do it as teacher, not as admin

Setup data for your Moodle Site

Suggestions

- Two courses
- Four user accounts
- Enrol your users as teachers, non-editing teachers, students
- For each course, add some resources and activities
- Add some data for each activity (make forum postings, submit assignment work, ...)

Customize your Moodle site

- Give your site a logo and a name
- Setup the site's mail sever

Provide details for your sites admin user

- Enter your name and email address

How far should you go

How far should you go with your experimentation?

With power comes responsibility

As admin user, you are pretty powerful

You can do anything the Moodle web user interface allows

What can go wrong?

- You can delete data in your Moodle site you in fact still might want
- You can get (very) confused (Moodle is a complex system)
- But, besides loosing data, in theory, you should be able to fix anything yourself

What I recommend

- Think before you make changes
- First do the steps we recommend
- Experiment more once you are more comfortable with how Moodle works

How far should you go

Where to get help if you are stuck

- Ask others around you (in the labs, online)
- Ask any of the teaching staff

If we cannot ‘fix’ your sites (with reasonable effort)

- We will re-create your site
- This means that you have to
  - Add all your data again – which won’t take that long

Feel free to experiment …